

# THE SAME HOUSE TWICE

---

**COLD OPEN, v1.0 — written by Fable, 2026-08-27**

---

**Pipeline step 4, first pass.** Written from spine v1.2. **Stephen-ruled 2026-08-27: this premise is no longer the Episode 1 candidate and is reassigned to episode 3 or 4.** *"This story is not going to be a candidate for ep1 but it certainly is looking good for #3 or #4."*

**Status: not locked, not VO-ready.** A tightening pass is briefed in `prompt-fable-tighten-the-same-house-twice.md`.

---

## THE OPENING

---

*Rain on the studio window. The record light clicks on.*

**ALLY:** Every episode of this show starts with a voice. A message on the tip line, a tape, somebody on the record. This one starts with a call I can't play you. The woman who made it asked me not to record her, so I didn't, and what you get instead is me, my notes, and you deciding whether I'm telling it straight.

She rang yesterday afternoon. She gave me her name, which took some nerve, and you're not getting it. She's a care worker. Twice a week she visits a woman called Winnie. Winnie is eighty-one. Rich, sharp, and rude in the way you're allowed to be when you made your own money and have outlived everyone who ever told you what to do with it. She lives up in Highcliff, where the streets are quiet and nobody knocks. She pays for two visits a week and spends both of them explaining that she doesn't need them. As of this week, the visits are cancelled. When the office rang to check, Winnie backed it. My caller heard what she told them: I'm eighty-one, I am not a parcel, stop signing for me.

But my caller wasn't ringing about Winnie. She was ringing about the man who does Winnie's shopping.

His name is Colin. The garden first, years ago. Then the shopping. This year, her heart pills, because the boxes are fiddly and he's there anyway. He remembers how she takes her tea. He is, by every account I have, a genuinely lovely man, and Winnie likes him. Everyone likes him. My caller liked him. Liked. Past tense. Then a long pause, and: I've met him before.

Five years ago she looked after a man in that same house. Same garden, same kind man carrying the shopping up the steps. She watched the man she cared for get tired, then confused, and then she watched him die. Later she heard the house had gone to the man who carried the shopping. She says if you look at that house, just the house, you'll find it happened before that too. Same house. Twice.

She told the people she works for, months ago, in writing. The answer came back: not yours to discuss. Not with anyone. Not with her. So she rang a podcast instead, and made sure there would be no tape of her doing it.

Here's the part I can't get past. Winnie isn't missing. Nobody is holding her. She's at home, furious about the fuss, and the one person in Havenbay who is kind to her without pity is the man my caller says is killing her. If I knock on that door with all of this, I know exactly what happens, because it's what I'd do. She picks him.

Maybe my caller is wrong. Maybe she's seen one bad thing too many and started seeing it everywhere. That happens, in her job and in mine. So I'm not going to Highcliff to rescue anybody. Winnie would hand me my head, and she'd have a point. I'm going to look at one house, and take my time, and tell you what I find.

This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn. Episode one. The Same House Twice.

---

## WHAT IT GETS RIGHT

---

Checked against the step-4 brief before anything else was said about it.

- **Three named people, not four.** Ally, Winnie, Colin. The caller is *my caller*. The doctor is absent.
- **No banned vocabulary.** *Her heart pills*, and nothing clinical or procedural anywhere.
- **No em dashes.**
- **Ally never addresses something that cannot answer.** She talks to the listener, which is the frame.
- **★ It turns the constraint into the hook.** *"This one starts with a call I can't play you."* The no-tape rule was a canon obligation and it became the first interesting thing in the episode.
- **★ It answers the standing voice flag.** A reader said Ally's phrasing reads as weird across two separate works and that the noir styling had to go if it was the cause. There is no pastiche here. *"Here's the part I can't get past."*
- **★ It states the episode's thesis in two sentences and is honest about Ally having no power.** *"If I knock on that door with all of this, I know exactly what happens, because it's what I'd do. She picks him."*
- **It keeps her doubt as an engine rather than decoration.** *"Maybe she's seen one bad thing too many."*
- **It promises no powers.** *"I'm not going to Highcliff to rescue anybody."*

**Lines to protect through any rewrite:** *I am not a parcel, stop signing for me · Liked. Past tense. · not yours to discuss. Not with anyone. Not with her. · She picks him. · Same house. Twice.*

---

## TIMING, AND WHY IT MOVED EPISODE

---

**537 words.** At podcast narration pace: **3:34** at a brisk 150wpm, **3:50** at 140, **4:07** at 130 with the pauses the writing implies.

| Lands at (@130wpm) | Words in | Beat                                                  |
|--------------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:29               | 62       | the call I can't play you                             |
| 1:29               | 192      | Winnie · <i>"I am not a parcel"</i>                   |
| 2:07               | 276      | Colin                                                 |
| <b>2:30</b>        | 351      | ★ <i>"she watched him die" · "Same house. Twice."</i> |
| 3:02               | 394      | the report that was filed and buried                  |
| <b>3:32</b>        | 460      | ★ <i>"She picks him"</i>                              |
| 4:07               | 537      | sign-off                                              |

**Against the FTUE as built** ( `feature-ftue-onboarding-v1.md` ): first interaction is currently **~57s of VO away**, which that spec already names as the problem, because **20% of installs die inside two minutes**. The I6 recommendation is to tighten toward **35 to 40 seconds**, still an open ruling.

★ **So as an Episode 1 opening this was roughly four times the current intro and six times the proposed target, and it back-loaded its own hook: the murder is not explicit until about two and a half minutes and the two best lines land at 2:30 and 3:32, both past the cliff.**

**That is a medium problem, not a writing problem.** It is paced correctly for a podcast, and a podcast listener has already chosen to listen where a mobile installer has not.

★ **Reassigning it to episode 3 or 4 dissolves most of it.** No FTUE, no tutorial, no install cliff, and a player who has already finished two cases will happily sit with Ally. **What survives the reassignment is only that the jeopardy still arrives late, and that everything in paragraphs 1 and 9 exists to orient a listener who, by episode 3, is not new.**

---

## NOTES ON THE FILE

---

**Fable's own note, and it is correct.** Winnie cannot lawfully be in this opening in her own voice, because Ally has not met her on Day 1, so her entire personhood rides on two fragments of reported speech. **If readers do not feel her, that seam is where**, and it cannot be closed until lead 5 puts her in a doorway.

**My note.** The opening asserts that Colin is killing her and never shows a symptom. Spine v1.2 has the attempt already under way and Winnie visibly declining, and **present-tense danger is this premise's whole answer to "no jeopardy, too safe."** One clause would fix it.

**Alternative title offered by Fable:** *The Kind Man*, if the man belongs at the front rather than the house. Not ruled.

△ **The sign-off says "Episode one" and must change with the slot.**

---

# ⚠ INHERITED DEBT, RECORDED SO NOBODY THINKS THIS IS CLEAN

---

Spine v1.2 went to prose in parallel with a third audit, and **that audit found four unrepaired defects. None of them is fixed.** Whoever builds this as episode 3 or 4 inherits all of them, and they are listed on the spine document itself.

Briefly: the recipients of every official action are missing from the earliest-action sweep, so the claimed latency is unpaid · **the antagonist's warning is dated after the refusal it is said to cause** · capacity is treated as permanent from Day 3 when it renews at lead 12 · and three first-action dates follow the authored lead order rather than earliest availability.

★ **The sweep has since gained a recipient column specifically because of this spine, and it has never been re-run on it.** Do that first.